

The Indian Factor

Americans of Asian origin, though a minority, have a significant say in some swing states apart from being major fundraisers for both candidates. A survey shows they are tilting to Obama

■ By Lavina Melwani in New York

With the meltdown on Wall Street and financial markets in the doldrums, with billions of dollars feeding an unending war, and housing and employment stagnant, the upcoming American presidential election pits two very different world-views against each other. For voters, it is a tough choice, between change and continuity, a choice between two very different leaders—Democrat Barack Obama and Republican John McCain. The 2.6 million-strong Indian-American community seems to be voting in line with the mainstream.

A new study released in Washington D.C. suggests that Indian-Americans are indeed leaning towards Obama, and that their votes could be the pivotal swing that decides the outcome of the race. According to the 2008 National Asian American Survey (NAAS), conducted by researchers in four American universities, 41 per cent of Asian-Americans are likely to vote for Obama, while 24 per cent support McCain. In battleground states, Obama leads with 43 per cent of the Asian-Americans supporting him and 22 per cent favouring McCain. The key component is the 34 per cent undecided Asian-American voters, a hefty number compared to the 8 per cent in the general electorate.

Karthick Ramakrishnan, an associate professor of political science at UC Riverside and one of the researchers of the study, points out that with such a high proportion of undecided voters, Asian-Americans are a critical source of potential votes. After the Latinos, Asian-Americans are the fastest-growing population in the US, making up 5 per cent of the US population today. Among Asian-Americans, those of Indian origin constitute 0.9 per cent of the total, followed by the



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Younger Indian Americans are coming of age and many of them are rooting for Obama.

Chinese with 1.2 per cent. According to the NAAS study, Asian-Americans will play an important role in battleground states such as Virginia, Nevada and Washington, where they account for five per cent or more of the population. Even in states such as Colorado, Ohio and Florida, where they are less numerous, Asian-Americans may pro-